SPORTS

TURNING THE TABLES



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*Table tennis player **Manika Batra** talks about the changing perception of the game and the rise of Indian women in the sport*

Q. 2024 was a breakthrough year for women's table tennis in India with five women in the top 100.
The year was incredible. If you see, not just women but even young girls are doing great. We won the Asian Table Tennis Championship bronze medal and at the Olympics, too, we made it to quarter-finals in the women's team and I reached the round of 16. I can see the growth. There's self-belief now. Earlier, the mindset was that we cannot win against the Chinese, but that's changed in the past few years. I defeated world #2 Wang Manyu.

Q. There's greater visibility for the game, too, courtesy the Ultimate Table Tennis league. Has that helped turn things around?
It's a great initiative because we get to play with and against foreign players. More people come to watch the games and it builds the popularity of table tennis. Earlier, the sport was seen as a hobby. Now, families think of putting their kids into table tennis to play at a higher competitive level.

Q. Tell us about the impact of working with your coach Aman Balgu.
I am very comfortable with him. I like how he pushes me during training. He has been a former player, so he knows how to handle one on and off the court. I remember I had a first-round loss in South Korea, and his pep talk after it really motivated me. Sometimes there are arguments like when I am not able to follow what he's teaching...but that's the nature of a player-coach bond; ultimately, you have to listen to him (*laughs*).

Q. What's your way to unwind?
Most of the time I am training in either Hyderabad or Mumbai or playing a tournament, so the free time I do get I like spending with my parents, grandmother and siblings in New Delhi. I love cafés, so I like trying coffees, especially in foreign countries. I like reading motivational books. I like to do visualisation and manifestation. In fact, for a long while, I was manifesting I'd defeat Wang Manyu and how I would react—and I finally did so at Saudi Smash [tournament]. ■

–with Suhani Singh